

GBA JAM 2026

PALADADO

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Introduction

Paladado (n.): A really fun GBA game submitted to GBA Jam 2026. The name is derived from the words “palabra” and “dados”, or the Spanish words for “word” and “dice”, respectively.

Paladado is a rogue-lite word game where you must find valid words from a grid of 4x4 letters to meet a point requirement that increases each level. You may submit up to four words to meet this point requirement.

After you meet the point requirement for the level, you may purchase dice, fonts and letters. You may then replace those dice in your set to increase the number of points per word you score and increase your chances of finding longer, higher scoring words.

If you score enough points to meet the increasing requirements for 15 levels, you beat the demo! Otherwise, if you don't meet the point requirement for a level, you lose the game.

Controls

On the board:

L: Clear Entire
Word

R: Submit
Word

A: Select Letters

B: Backspace

D-Pad: Move Cursor

Select: Display
Guide



In the shop:



R: Restock Shop

A: Select Item
for Purchase

D-Pad: Move Cursor

Select: Display
Guide

In the shop (cont.)



D-Pad: Move
Cursor/
Rotate
Selected Die

Select: Display
Guide

A: View each face
/ Apply Item to
Die/Face

Gameplay

You start a round with your dice randomly ordered and rolled on the board:



Gameplay (cont.)

Select up to four words for submission. Two have been highlighted for your convenience:



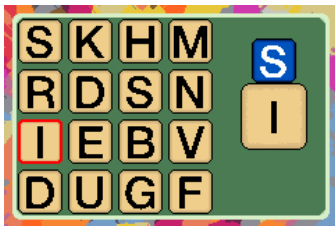
Gameplay (cont.)

Once you have met the point requirement for the round, you will see this screen. Press the A button to go to the shop.



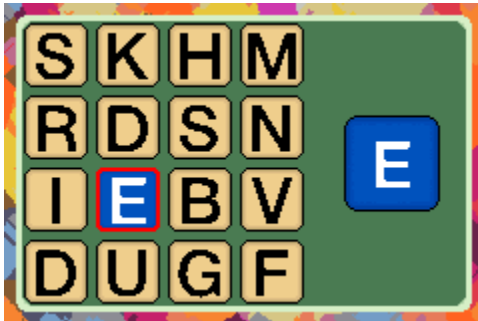
Gameplay (cont.)

Here in the shop, you can purchase dice, letters or fonts to swap out ones in your set. Press A on an item if you wish to purchase it. If you do, the shop will take you to your current dice to apply the item.



Gameplay (cont.)

There, you can apply your item to a die by pressing A.



Gameplay (cont.)

You may view your current dice without needing to purchase an item by pressing right on the D-Pad until you see the dice.

You may leave the shop and continue to the next level by pressing B on the shop screen.

In-Game Guides:

Forget what a certain die or letter does? Just press the Select button while on the board, shop or current dice screens. This brings up a guide screen that reminds you what that die's features are.

Ending the Game:

You play until you either win (beat 15 levels) or lose (fail to meet the point requirement for a level).

Valid Word Requirements

For a word to be valid, it must meet the following criteria:

- Words must be three to eight letters in length.
- The word must not be a previously submitted word
 - Words within words are allowed, such as "mast" and "aster" within "master".
- Each letter after the first must be a horizontal, vertical, or diagonal neighbor of the one before it.
 - There are exceptions to this rule; see the ***Letter Effects*** section of this booklet
- No individual letter cube may be used more than once in a word.
- No proper nouns (typically capitalized words) or hyphenated words are allowed.

Earning Money

There are three ways which you earn money to purchase items in the shop:

- When you complete a level, you earn \$3 times the number of words you had yet to submit. For example, if you submitted two words, you would earn \$6, \$3 for each extra word you could have submitted
- If you exceed the point requirement for the round, you gain the number of points you exceed the score by (maximum of \$5)
- If you include a green die in your word, you gain money equal to the base score for the word length.

Scoring Formula

Scored Points
=
Base Score for Word Length + Additional Bonus Points
x Score Multiplier

- When calculating your score for a word, the additional bonus points are added to the base score before the score multiplier is applied.

Scoring Formula

Base Score per Word						
Length of Word	3	4	5	6	7	8+
Base Score	1	1	2	3	5	11

Point Requirement by Level

Level	Points Required to Pass	Level	Points Required to Pass
1	2	11	32
2	3	12	38
3	4	13	44
4	6	14	51
5	8	15	58
6	11		
7	14		
8	18		
9	22		
10	27		

Dice Effects:

In the bottom section of the store, you may purchase dice. The dice apply effects that occur when a particular die is included in a word.



No Color: No effect

Black: When a word includes a black die, all adjacent cubes not previously used in the word are temporarily replaced with wildcard letters.

- If you choose a die that had “Qu” on it, it counts as two wildcard letters

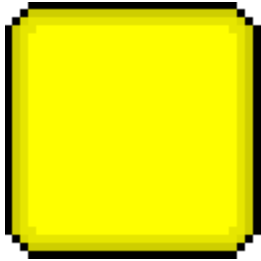
Dice Effects (cont.)



Brown: Including a brown die in a word re-rolls all adjacent dice to the brown die on the board after scoring.

Red: When a word includes a red die, the word gains +3 additional bonus points.

Dice Effects (cont.)



Orange: An orange die grants additional bonus points equal to the number of turns in a word. The more twists and turns you have in your word, the higher the additional bonus points. *A straight line gives no points.*

Yellow: Including a yellow die in a word adds a x2 score multiplier to the next word found. This multiplier stacks with other multipliers.

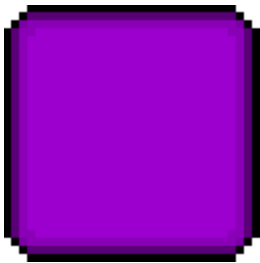
Dice Effects (cont.)



Green: You gain extra money equal to the point value of the word if a green die is included in the word (maximum of 11).

Blue: When a word includes a blue die, the word is treated as if it is one letter longer for scoring purposes.

Dice Effects (cont.)



Purple: A purple die adds a +5 score multiplier if the word includes at least two other colored dice in the word.

Gray: Including a gray die means you may skip an adjacent letter (effectively removing the next letter from the submitted word). The excluded die's effect is still included in scoring.

Dice Effects (cont.)



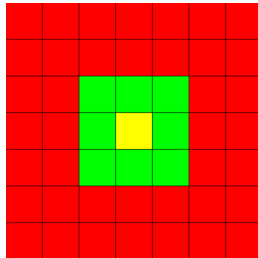
White: Each die included after a white die adds cumulative bonus points. For example, if there are 3 dice after a white die, the bonus points are $3+2+1 = 6$

Letter Effects

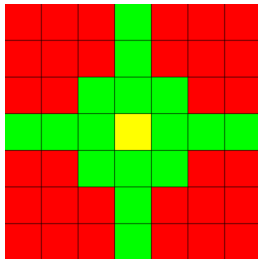
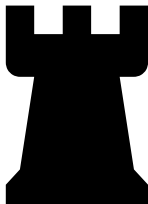
In the top section of the store, you may purchase letters with special effects. These allow you to access extra spaces in addition to all unused adjacent letters. In the explanatory diagram, the colors represent the spaces as follows:

- **Yellow** – Current Letter Space
- **Red** – Invalid Spaces
- **Green** – Available Spaces (excluding previously selected letters)

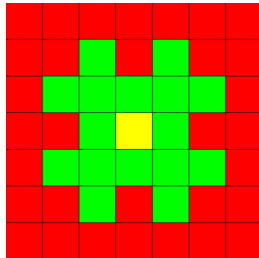
Note: These diagrams show a 7x7 space, to show all possible spaces accessible to the piece.



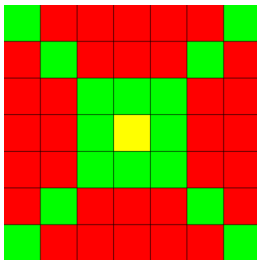
Normal Font – No Additional Spaces



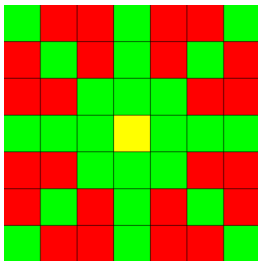
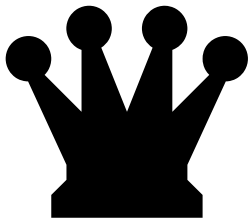
Plus Seal – Rook Spaces



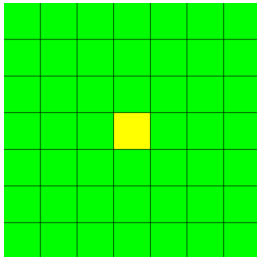
L Seal – Knight Spaces



X Seal – Bishop Spaces



Star Seal – Queen Spaces



Comic Sans – All Unused Spaces

Credits

Programming & Visual Assets – Christopher Thompson

Music & Sound Effects – Craig Henderson

Playtesters – A. Dixon, J. Dixon, H. Thompson, J. Thompson, S. Wolford

Programmed with Butano (C++)

Visual Assets created with Blender, GIMP, and Python

Fonts Used – Helvetica Neue Medium, Comic Sans

Audio Assets created with Ableton, MiniBit and Super Audio Cart 2

GBA Splashscreen -

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[List of Valid Words](#) - in the Public Domain